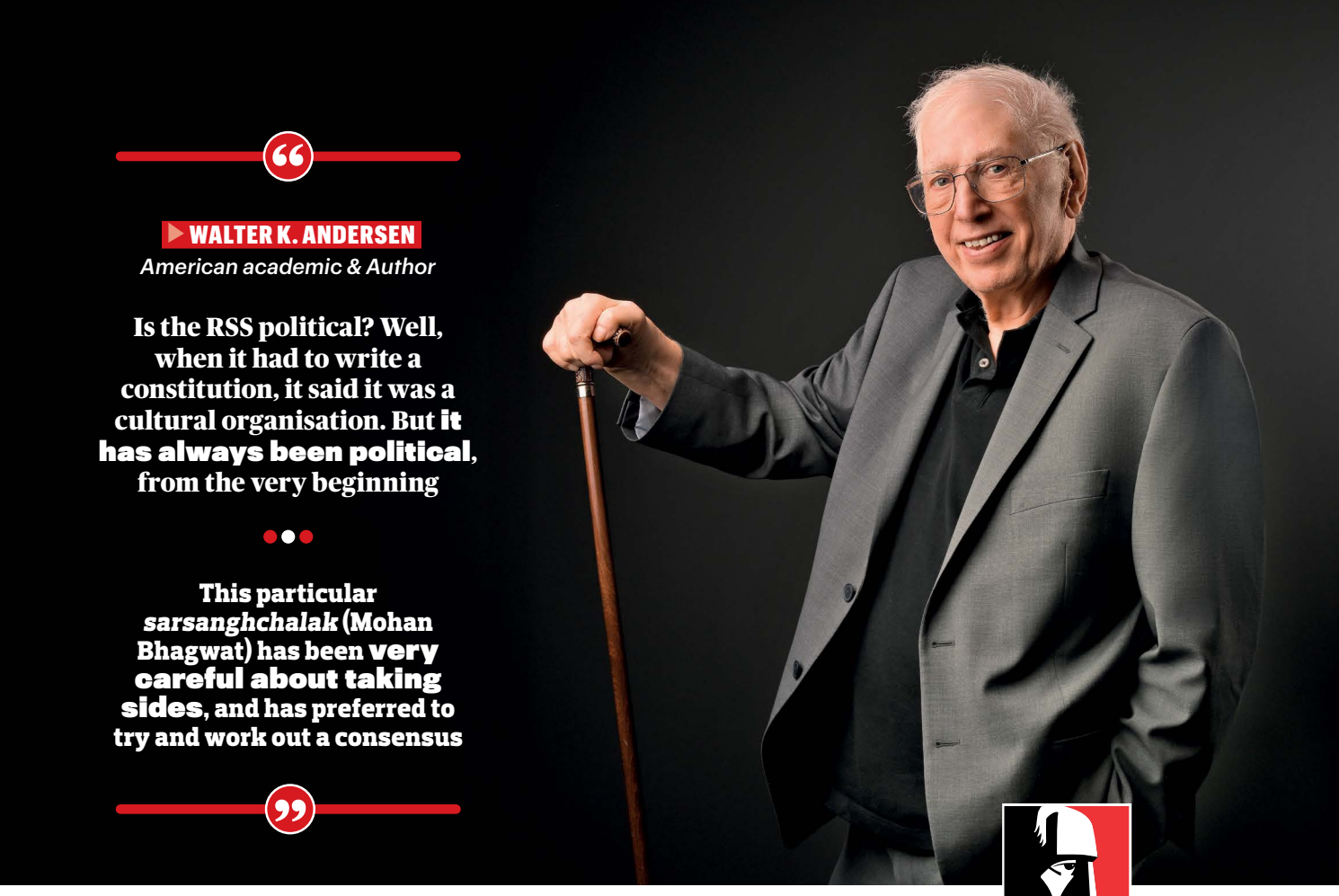


WALTER K. ANDERSEN
American academic & Author

Is the RSS political? Well, when it had to write a constitution, it said it was a cultural organisation. But it has always been political, from the very beginning

This particular *sarsanghchalak* (Mohan Bhagwat) has been very careful about taking sides, and has preferred to try and work out a consensus

THE MANY LIVES OF THE SANGH



DOUBLE ENGINE IN OVERDRIVE?
THE RSS-BJP TANGO

American academician and author Walter K. Andersen, who has co-authored two books on the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), made a bit of a revelation at the India Today Conclave. He said that contrary to the public perception of the Sangh as an iron-clad, authoritarian body, the organisation—which turns 100 this year—has its share of internal debates and disagreements. "It has always had disagreements which have been spelt out. So, it is not as if you have a kind of a quasi-dictator at the top who tells everybody what to do," said Andersen. "I was always amazed in relating to the people in the RSS, the extent that you had internal divisions and debates, including on how closely to be related to the present government in India."

But when a decision was made, the RSS affiliates were firm that they should follow the advice of the leadership. The unity of India and the concept of it as the motherland has always been the major ideological framework of the RSS. A factor in the growth of the RSS was the nature of the organisation—since its inception in 1925, the group had always focused on creating a sense of family. Andersen also tried to clear the air on some of the tropes the Sangh has been foisted with over the years, including it being anti-women, Brahminical, anti-Muslim and much else. Clearly, "complex questions" which elicited complex answers. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **When you hear RSS head Mohan Bhagwat talk of Muslims as if they're Hindus, what he means is Hinduism as a kind of large ethnic group, a culture rooted in this country**
- **The RSS grew so fast because, from the beginning, the group focused on the sense of a family**